

Yakima Free Clinic - Volunteer Handbook

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Welcome Statement

Welcome to Yakima Free Clinic! We are so glad you're here. Your decision to give your time and energy to this work means more than you may realize. Every person who walks through our doors is met with compassion, dignity, and hope—and that is only possible because of people like you.

At our clinic, volunteers are the heart of what we do. Whether you are greeting patients, helping with intake, providing medical care, or organizing supplies, you are part of a team that makes real, lasting impact in our community. Together, we not only provide care, but also build trust and connection for those who might otherwise go without.

Our tagline captures the spirit of who we are: *Together we serve, Together we learn, Together we heal* | *Juntos servimos, Juntos aprendemos, Juntos Curamos*. You'll find that this isn't just a phrase we use—it's how we live out our mission every day. We serve side by side, we learn from one another and from our patients, and in doing so, we create space for healing that goes beyond medicine.

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I want you to know how deeply valued you are here. We don't take your presence for granted. Thank you for stepping into this role with kindness, patience, and commitment. I'm excited to work alongside you and to see the many ways you will make a difference.

Sincerely,
Hannah Wilson PA-C
Executive Director, Yakima Free Clinic

Our board and our staff are committed to supporting you and ensuring a positive and rewarding experience as you serve our community. All volunteers are expected to adhere to the guidelines and requirements outlined in this handbook. Failure to comply with these standards may result in corrective actions or, in some cases, termination of volunteer service at Yakima Free Clinic. If you have any questions or concerns, please reach out to your team leader or a staff member for assistance.

Introduction

Yakima Free Clinic or La Clínica Gratuita de Yakima is a 501c3 Washington State Nonprofit Organization. As codified in our Articles of Incorporation, the **mission** of Yakima Free Clinic is to provide free, holistic healthcare to the medically underserved of Central Washington State, to provide student experiences and training for healthcare and pre-healthcare students, and to conduct and carry out the other work of the organization, not for profit, but exclusively for humanitarian, educational, and public service purposes.

Our **vision** is to meet the critical needs of our community by providing a medical clinic *funded primarily by donors and delivered primarily by volunteers*, where:

- All healthcare services are provided free of charge.
- Medically underserved patients are prioritized.
 - Primary focus is given to patients underserved due to lack of insurance.
 - Patients medically underserved for other reasons (inability to afford copays, lack of care availability, etc.) will also be provided care.
- Educational opportunities are provided for healthcare and pre-healthcare students in our community.

Volunteering with YFC is a privilege and not a right; nothing in this handbook should be construed to constitute a contract or guarantee a place volunteering with this organization.

Yakima Free Clinic Roles

Board of Directors: Yakima Free Clinic is governed by its Articles of Incorporation and its bylaws. These documents can be available upon request to any volunteer. YFC is led by a Board of Directors who delegates daily operations and leadership to the Executive Director.

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Executive Director: Provides leadership, guidance and continuity to the clinic. Oversees all aspects of operation including patient care, volunteers, building operations, budget and fundraising.

Patient Coordinator: Responsible for running the front desk during clinic open hours, assists with patient care coordination and volunteer organization.

Volunteers: core workforce of the clinic providing the majority of support for patient care, education, clinic organization, care coordination, building maintenance, etc.

Volunteer Team Leaders: Volunteers at Yakima Free Clinic are organized into teams, each with a designated leader who manages activities for their group. Your team leader will be your primary point of contact for any matters related to your service at the clinic.

Onboarding

Volunteer Openings

We are always seeking healthcare workers and interpreters to join our team. Openings for non-clinical volunteers (such as administrative or clerical positions) are more limited. If you know someone who is interested in volunteering, please ask a staff member for information about current opportunities. While we generally do not allow individuals under the age of 18 to volunteer, exceptions may be made for children of current volunteers or for students who are completing projects or enrolled in healthcare training programs.

Onboarding Process

1. Initial Contact & Application Review

After completing an online application, each volunteer receives a confirmation email with next steps. The application is reviewed, and potential roles are identified or follow-up communication is arranged if needed.

2. Document Collection & Screening

Volunteer submits required documentation such as background checks, ID verification, signed handbook, and certifications. Compliance status is tracked and confirmed before moving forward. When completing the volunteer application, new volunteers consent to a criminal background check, as well as licensure verification if applicable. Additionally, criminal background checks and licensure verification (if required) are conducted periodically for current volunteers to maintain accurate and up-to-date records.

3. Orientation & Training

Volunteer attends an orientation session. Attendance is recorded, and access to training materials is provided.

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- Onboarding training refers to general training regarding care for patients and co-volunteers. Your team leader will ensure that you receive all necessary training for your role. This may include general role descriptions, specific procedures or protocols, and other essential information to prepare you to serve effectively at the clinic.

4. Scheduling & Activation

Volunteer selects first shifts through the portal, is assigned to a role, and receives instructions for time tracking, expectations, and points of contact.

5. First Shift & Ongoing Engagement

Volunteer arrives for their first shift, completes any outstanding training, receives a check-in from a coordinator, and is welcomed into communication channels. A feedback survey is sent after the first shift.

Volunteer Scheduling

Volunteers are asked to arrive 15 minutes before their scheduled shift. Shifts typically last 4–5 hours, but you are welcome to extend your service if needed. Prompt arrival is important, and upon arriving, don't forget to sign in at the break room computer. If you need to reschedule or cancel, please notify the clinic as soon as possible, giving as much advance notice as you can. For last-minute changes, contact Yakima Free Clinic at (509) 731-3501.

Communication

We use various methods to keep volunteers informed and engaged. These include posted announcements, newsletters, text messages, emails, and updates through team leaders.

Confidentiality

Protecting patient privacy is a critical aspect of providing care at Yakima Free Clinic. All volunteers are legally required to maintain patient confidentiality. Information shared within the clinic must remain private and must not be disclosed to anyone outside the clinic. All volunteers must sign a confidentiality agreement as part of their service. The federal Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) sets the standards for confidentiality in healthcare, and we require compliance with this law. Documents containing identifying information (such as names, dates of birth, or patient record numbers) must be disposed of in the confidential shred bins located throughout the facility.

Conflict of Interest

To uphold the highest ethical standards, Yakima Free Clinic requires all volunteers to follow strict policies regarding conflicts of interest. Volunteers must avoid activities such as:

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- Accepting tips or gifts from patients in exchange for services or benefits. Any financial gift must be given as a donation to the clinic as a whole. Small homemade gifts of nominal value can be accepted when it would be culturally rude to refuse.
- Falsifying information on volunteer applications.
- Using their position for personal gain.
- Requesting special favors from staff or volunteers on behalf of a relative, friend, patient, or another organization.
- Failing to report known false statements made by a patient or volunteer.
- Altering or falsifying patient information or chart records.

Volunteer Expectations and Reporting Concerns

Volunteers are expected to treat patients with friendliness, professionalism, and respect. Any complaints regarding the treatment of patients or volunteers will be documented and reviewed. Complaints about patients should be directed to the Medical Director, Executive Director or Patient Coordinator, while complaints about staff members should be referred to the Executive Director. Complaints about volunteers will be reviewed and addressed appropriately by the clinic's leadership team.

Boundary Setting

As a volunteer with Yakima Free Clinic, it is essential to establish and maintain healthy boundaries to foster a safe and effective environment for patients, staff, and fellow volunteers. Proper boundary-setting ensures the well-being of everyone involved and helps create a professional and supportive atmosphere. This section of the handbook outlines key guidelines and expectations regarding boundary-setting and provides practical strategies to help you maintain appropriate boundaries throughout your volunteer experience.

Understanding Boundaries

- Boundaries are personal limits and guidelines that define appropriate behavior, interactions, and relationships between people.
- Boundaries help create a safe and respectful environment, ensuring that volunteers, staff, and clients feel comfortable and supported.

Boundaries with Clients

- Maintain professional conduct
 - Act respectfully and professionally with all patients, treating them with dignity, empathy, and compassion.
- Respect confidentiality
 - Adhere to strict confidentiality guidelines and avoid discussing or disclosing any confidential patient information.

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- Maintain appropriate physical boundaries
 - Respect personal space and avoid any physical contact that may be misunderstood or make patients uncomfortable.
- Avoid compromising relationships
 - Refrain from relationships with patients that may compromise objectivity or create a conflict of interest. This includes personal friendships, romantic relationships, or financial transactions.
- Respect personal contact information
 - It is vital to safeguard client confidentiality and privacy. Avoid requesting or providing personal contact information such as phone numbers, social media accounts, or home addresses.

Boundaries with Staff and Other Volunteers

- Foster a collaborative environment
 - Work cooperatively with staff and fellow volunteers, demonstrating equal respect, good communication, and teamwork.
- Respect professional boundaries
 - Understand the roles of staff members and volunteers, recognizing that certain decisions and responsibilities are within the scope of staff members only.

Personal Appearance / Dress Code

The appearance of volunteers at the Yakima Free Clinic should be both professional and appropriate for maintaining safety and aligning with the values of the clinic. Volunteers and staff are expected to present themselves in a neat, clean, and professional manner, ensuring their appearance does not distract from the overall professionalism of the clinic. Clothing, accessories, and personal adornments (e.g., tattoos, body piercings, hair color, etc.) should not be distracting or offensive to patients, staff, or other volunteers. Volunteers who do not meet these guidelines may be asked to end their shift early and return at a later time in compliance with the dress code. It is recommended to avoid strong fragrances to protect the health of patients and volunteers.

The following guidelines help define what is considered appropriate attire at the clinic:

- All volunteers and staff are required to wear name tags while at the clinic.
- Only pants or skirts that are below the knee are allowed—no shorts.
- No visible cleavage or midriffs.
- Yoga pants, workout clothes, and ripped jeans are not permitted.
- Students and trainees are encouraged to wear their school uniforms and name tags while completing clinical hours at the Yakima Free Clinic.

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- Closed-toed shoes are strongly encouraged to protect your feet adequately while volunteering.

If you have any questions or concerns about these guidelines, please discuss them with your Volunteer Team Leader or the Office Manager.

Drug, Alcohol, and Tobacco-Free Workplace

At Yakima Free Clinic, we strive to maintain a safe and healthy work environment for our volunteers, clients, and staff. Our Drug, Alcohol, and Tobacco-Free Workplace Guideline is designed to ensure a productive and respectful atmosphere. As a volunteer, you are expected to comply with the following guidelines:

Drugs and Alcohol:

- Volunteers must not use, possess, distribute, or be under the influence of illegal drugs, controlled substances, or alcohol while volunteering.
- This applies when reporting for duty, during volunteer assignments, on Yakima Free Clinic premises or surrounding areas, and in any vehicle used for Yakima Free Clinic business.
- Any convictions related to drug or alcohol offenses must be promptly disclosed to Yakima Free Clinic.

Solicitation

- Volunteers are not allowed to approach employees or distribute literature during work hours or in any work area, except during agency-sponsored events. However, volunteers may approach and engage in conversations with employees who are on break, as long as both parties are in a designated break area away from clients and working employees. It is important to note that discussions should not involve the promotion of religious beliefs.

By upholding this, we aim to create a welcoming and inclusive environment that respects the diversity of Yakima Free Clinic.

Equal Opportunity and Anti-Discrimination

Yakima Free Clinic is committed to providing equal opportunity to all individuals, including volunteers. We value the talents and contributions of every volunteer and strive to create an inclusive and respectful environment.

Equal Opportunity:

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- Yakima Free Clinic prohibits discrimination against volunteers based on race, color, ethnicity, national origin, religion, sex/gender, sexual orientation, disability status, age, or any other trait protected under local, state, or federal law.
- All volunteers are entitled to fair and equal treatment in recruitment, assignments, training, and other aspects of their volunteer experience.

Accommodations:

- Yakima Free Clinic is committed to exploring and providing reasonable accommodations for volunteers with disabilities and accommodating religious practices whenever possible.

Harassment Prohibited:

- Harassment of any volunteer based on race, religion, national origin, citizenship, sex/gender, sexual orientation, veteran status, disability, leave status, or age is strictly prohibited and will not be tolerated. It contradicts Yakima Free Clinic's values.

Our Commitment to You:

- Yakima Free Clinic is dedicated to maintaining a harassment-free work environment, addressing harassment claims promptly, and preventing retaliation against individuals who report claims or participate in investigations.

Your Role:

- As a volunteer, you play an essential role in upholding this guideline. We rely on your help to maintain a respectful and inclusive environment. If you witness or experience any form of harassment or discrimination, we encourage you to report it to your direct supervisor, Office Manager, or Executive Director immediately.

Workplace Violence

It is strictly prohibited for any individual to engage in conduct, whether verbal, physical, or otherwise, that intimidates, endangers, or creates the perception of harm to persons or property. Examples of prohibited conduct include, but are not limited to:

- Physical assaults or threats of physical assault, whether in person or through communication methods (such as writing, phone calls, text messages, or emails).
- Verbal conduct intended to intimidate or threaten someone's health or safety.
- Any other acts or conduct that management deems as an immediate or potential threat to workplace safety or security.

In line with this practice, Yakima Free Clinic strictly prohibits the possession of firearms or any other lethal weapons on agency premises, parking facilities, or at work-related functions. This applies to all employees, visitors, volunteers, and customers, even those with valid weapon licenses.

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In the unlikely event of an emergency where you believe someone is in immediate danger, please call 911 and then notify a staff member regarding the situation.

Whistleblower Policy

This Whistleblower Policy is intended to express and promote YFC's open door policy and to encourage volunteers to share their questions, concerns, suggestions or complaints with YFC leadership so they can be properly addressed.

YFC will investigate complaints of fraudulent or dishonest use or misuse of YFC's resources or property by directors, volunteers, employees, or any other agents of YFC. Any person found to have engaged in fraudulent or dishonest conduct will be subject to corrective action and may face civil action or referral to criminal prosecution if the conduct warrants such action. All volunteers are encouraged to report possible conduct that is unsafe, in violation of this Handbook, illegal, discriminatory, or in any way harmful to YFC, its volunteers, staff, or the patients that we serve. Volunteers should promptly report such activity to their Team Leader, Office Manager, or Executive Director as appropriate.

Complainants are responsible for being candid and providing all known information regarding suspected misconduct to the investigator who is designated to look into the complaint.

Investigations may not proceed if the complainant refuses to be interviewed by the investigator or refuses to provide further information regarding the complaint. Complainants should not conduct investigation activities themselves, nor do they have the right to participate in investigation activities, unless requested by the investigator. Complainants must refrain from obtaining evidence relating to a complaint for which they do not have a right of access. Such improper access may itself be misconduct and may result in corrective action. Complainants should also refrain from discussing the investigation or their testimony with those not connected to the investigation. A person who is concerned about suspected misconduct:

- Should not contact the person suspected in order to investigate the matter or demand restitution;
- Should not discuss the suspected misconduct with anyone other than the person's immediate supervisor, the Executive Director, the Board Chair, YFC's legal counsel, or a duly authorized law enforcement officer;
- Should direct all inquiries from an attorney retained by the suspected individual to YFC's legal counsel; and
- Should direct all inquiries from the media to the Executive Director

Any person who is not a complainant, but who is interviewed as part of an investigation, is expected not to discuss the nature of the evidence or any testimony given in the investigation except with the investigator, or unless otherwise authorized by the investigator or the Board.

Reasonable care shall be taken in dealing with suspected misconduct to avoid baseless accusations, premature notice to persons suspected of misconduct and/or disclosure of suspected

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misconduct to those not involved in the investigation, or the violation of a person's rights under the law.

CWMR will protect complainants who in good faith report suspected misconduct according to the No Retaliation policy.

No Retaliation

YFC prohibits retaliation against any volunteer who makes a good faith complaint of unlawful discrimination or harassment, opposes a practice they reasonably believe constitutes unlawful harassment, or who testifies, acts as a witness or otherwise assists in a related investigation. If you feel that you have been subjected to retaliation, immediately report it to the Office Manager or Executive Director. YFC further prohibits retaliation against any volunteer who raises a concern in good faith regarding the safety of any patient.

Lactation/Breastfeeding Needs

Volunteers with lactation or breastfeeding needs are encouraged to make a request for accommodations to the Office Manager, who will assist in making appropriate arrangements.

Usage of On-site Technology

Computers, email systems, and software provided by the Yakima Free Clinic are intended for clinic purposes only. Volunteers are expected to use these resources ethically and professionally. Copiers and printers at the clinic are intended for business use. If you need to print personal items, please speak with the Office Manager for guidance, as the clinic incurs costs associated with supplies and equipment upkeep.

The following are prohibited uses of clinic technology:

- Accessing or sharing defamatory, inappropriate, or potentially harmful content.
- Sending unsanctioned solicitations or promoting personal or external activities.
- Posting clinic-related content that violates privacy or confidentiality policies.

Social Media

In general, YFC respects the right of its volunteers to use social networking sites (e.g., Facebook, Instagram), personal websites, and blogs. If a volunteer chooses to identify themselves as a volunteer of YFC on such Internet venues, some readers of such websites or blogs may view the volunteer as a representative or spokesperson of YFC. In light of this possibility, YFC requires that volunteers observe the following guidelines when referring to YFC, its activities, staff, and/or other volunteers, in a blog or on a website.

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- Volunteers must respect the privacy rights of others associated with YFC and refrain from referencing or identifying them in any communications, blogs, social media and/or on websites on the internet.
- Volunteers must not use blogs, social media and/or on websites on the internet to discuss engaging in conduct that is prohibited by YFC policies, including, but not limited to, the use of illegal drugs, unlawful discrimination, or harassment.
- Volunteers should not use blogs, social media and/or on websites on the internet to express opinions or positions that may be seen as those of the organization without the approval of the Executive Director.
- Social media use should not interfere with the volunteer's activities with YFC.
- Volunteers must not post pictures, videos, or other media on the internet identifying any patient, volunteer or staff without first obtaining permission from the Executive Director.

Any volunteer found to be in violation of any portion of this policy may be subject to immediate disciplinary action, up to and including revocation of YFC volunteering activities.

Social media use should represent the clinic positively, align with the clinic's mission, and comply with patient privacy laws. Volunteers are encouraged to share the clinic's impact but should clarify their views are personal if they do not represent the clinic officially.

Media Requests

Please direct all media requests to the Executive Director of Yakima Free Clinic. We ask that no volunteers speak with the media regarding the clinic unless expressly asked by the Executive Director.

Public Forums and Speaking Engagements

No volunteer of YFC may speak at a public forum or speaking engagement as a representative of YFC without the prior approval of the Executive Director. Honoraria, gifts, and other payments or benefits offered to the volunteer in relation to such speaking engagements shall be donations to YFC and shall not be retained by the individual volunteer.

Lobbying and Political Activity

No volunteer of YFC shall, on behalf of YFC, engage in any lobbying or political activity, including carrying of propaganda or otherwise attempting to influence legislation, nor shall any volunteer, on behalf of YFC, participate in or intervene in any political campaign on behalf of (or in opposition to) any candidate for public office (including the publishing or distributing of statements), without the express consent and direction of the Board of Directors. Nothing in this section shall be construed to limit YFC volunteers from participating in such activities when not representing YFC.

Parking

We strive to prioritize parking spaces for our patients to ensure their access and comfort. During clinic open hours, volunteers and staff should park in the alley between 3rd and 4th Ave or any

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parking spots in the area except the main parking lot directly connected to the clinic. Kindly use parking spaces further from the building unless you have mobility concerns. Please use the main entrance to access the clinic and ensure your car is locked. We recommend placing valuables, including purses, in your trunk before arriving at the clinic.

Where Food is Allowed Onsite

Volunteers are encouraged to keep meals within the designated break room area. Eating at your workstations or in front of patients is discouraged to maintain professionalism. However, keeping a bottle of water or other beverages at your station is acceptable. You can store snacks and lunches in the refrigerator in the break room but remember to take home any leftovers.

Avoid Personal Healthcare Consultations

Volunteers should refrain from asking medical staff, counselors, or dentists for personal medical advice or treatment while at the clinic. This includes any informal or "curbside" consultations.

Requests for Recommendations

Yakima Free Clinic is happy to provide recommendations for volunteers seeking educational or employment opportunities, provided they have volunteered for at least one year or accumulated 40 total volunteer hours. This allows the clinic to provide a meaningful and informed recommendation. We can also issue service verification documents upon request for all volunteers. Hours are tracked through Volgistics, our volunteer management system.

Universal Precautions

We take every precaution to protect patients, volunteers, and staff from exposure to blood or body fluids. Personal protective equipment (PPE) is always available for your safety. This includes providing masks to patients who are coughing, wearing gowns as necessary, and more. Your Team Leader will offer guidance on the appropriate use of universal precautions in your work area.

Emergency Response

Emergencies can occur in any healthcare setting, and it's essential to understand your role in these situations. Your Volunteer Team Leader or a staff member will orient you on specific emergency procedures relevant to your work. Charts summarizing our emergency plans are posted throughout the clinic, and you are encouraged to review them. For any questions, please reach out to your team leader or a staff member.

When You Are Not Feeling Well

Your well-being is important to us at the Yakima Free Clinic. If you are not feeling well, we encourage you to stay home until you are feeling better. This will help you recover more quickly and ensures a safe and healthy environment for everyone at the clinic. If you need to cancel a volunteer shift, please contact your team leader or the clinic at (509) 731-3501.

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- **If you have cold/flu/COVID symptoms**, please do not report to the clinic for your volunteer shift. Instead, contact your team leader to reschedule.
 - If you have obvious symptoms (e.g., coughing or sneezing) when you arrive at the clinic, you may be asked to return home to take care of yourself until your symptoms have improved.

Guidelines for Interpreters

Volunteer Interpreters at the Yakima Free Clinic are expected to follow the guidelines below. These are adapted from the Washington State Department of Social & Health Services Language Interpreter and Translator Code of Professional Conduct.

1. Accuracy

Interpreters/translators must always convey the source language message in a thorough and faithful manner. They must omit nothing, consider linguistic variations in both the source and target languages, and maintain the tone and intent of the original message.

2. Cultural Sensitivity and Courtesy

Interpreters/translators must be culturally sensitive and respectful toward all individuals they serve.

3. Confidentiality

Interpreters/translators must keep all information obtained during their assignments confidential. This includes any information learned from conversations, documents, or other materials.

4. Proficiency

Interpreters/translators must be knowledgeable in the terminology relevant to the area in which they are interpreting. Those not proficient in medical, or counseling terminology should not interpret in those areas. Volunteer interpreters may be assessed for skills before interpreting in clinical settings.

5. Self-Representation

Interpreters/translators must truthfully represent their certifications, training, proficiency, and experience.

6. Impartiality – Conflict of Interest

Interpreters/translators must disclose any real or potential conflicts of interest that could affect their professional objectivity.

7. Professional Demeanor

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Interpreters/translators must be punctual, prepared, and dressed in a manner appropriate for the situation, avoiding anything distracting.

8. Scope of Practice

Interpreters/translators must not:

- Counsel, refer, provide advice, or express personal opinions to the individuals for whom they are interpreting/translating.
- Engage in non-translation-related activities with patients.
- Have unsupervised access to patients, including contacting them directly unless requested by clinic staff.
- Market their services to patients.
- Transport patients.

9. Reporting Obstacles to Practice

Interpreters/translators must evaluate their ability to perform their duties at all times.

- If there are any concerns about competency, interpreters/translators must notify clinic staff immediately and offer to withdraw.
- Interpreters/translators must withdraw from encounters that they perceive to violate this code of conduct.

By upholding these guidelines, volunteer interpreters play a vital role in fostering clear communication and creating a welcoming environment for everyone at the Yakima Free Clinic.